Spring
2026

Asterisk*

The Yale Journal of Art and Art History

Asterisk*

Memory and Material

Masthead

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Dear Asterisk* Readers,

We are excited to share with you the eleventh issue of Asterisk*: The Yale Undergraduate Journal of Art and Art History. This spring's edition is devoted to the twin themes of memory and material, and the artwork and scholarship within explore their intersection.

Our four essays, selected from submissions sent in from all across the world, illuminate just how memory is materialized. Together, they offer a broad sampling of artistic approaches, surveying artwork separated by both millennia and thousands of miles. In these pages, you'll encounter Song Dynasty ceramics and their Neolithic inspiration. You'll discover the late-medieval world of a van Eyck panel and contemporary battles over its restoration. You'll learn of controversial interpretations of the Mexican Revolution. And you'll see Marc Chagall grapple with thousands of years of Jewish history in stained glass designed for a brand new nation. Our authors have grappled with a meaty subject: the artistic confrontation of the past. In doing so, they trace the tenuous thread of historical memory embedded within the materials—whether ceramic, paint, ink, or glass.

Though we received so many fascinating insights into the current world of undergraduate art historical scholarship, we are thrilled to present these essays.

We are also thrilled to share a tightly curated collection of artwork by talented undergraduates. Each impressed us with their innovative use of different media, and in this way, our selected artworks speak to the themes of memory and materiality reflected in our essays.

In composing and designing this issue, we were continually reliant on the help and participation of so many students, including the authors and artists who submitted, our editors, who selected and refined the essays, and our layout team. To all of you, students, who made this issue possible—thank you.

We would also like to thank Professors Milette Gaifman and Joanna Fiduccia, as well as the entire History of Art Department at Yale University, for their enduring support and encouragement of Asterisk* and our publication efforts.

Please enjoy the Spring 2026 issue of Asterisk*.

Best,
Elijah Hurewitz-Ravitch and Alex Geldzahler
Editors-In-Chief

“BACK WHEN TIGERS USED TO SMOKE”

2023
OIL PAINT ON CANVAS
48 IN. X 36 IN.

AUDREY BAE
RHODE ISLAND SCHOOL OF DESIGN

Painting is a way that I explore my relationship to my culture and positionality in the world as a second generation Korean American woman. I integrate both classical oil painting techniques and traditional minhwa iconography in my work. I reimagine and allude to Korean folktales much like old masters and Renaissance painters would utilize Greek mythology, western literature, and the Bible. Combining and subverting painting ideals lets me navigate themes of the Korean diaspora and girlhood in spite of the Western art canon and its historical exclusion of women of color.

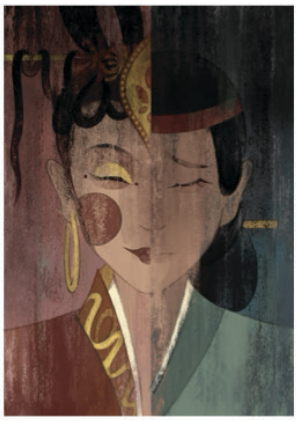
Serpent Chronicles

Wanxin Li
Pratt Institute

Digital Illustration 2024

This project explores the shifting symbolism of snakes in ancient Chinese culture, reflecting the transition from a matriarchal society to a patriarchal one and its impact on women's status. By examining this evolution, the project critiques contemporary issues surrounding women's rights, especially regarding family roles and autonomy over their bodies.

The first illustration depicts a matriarchal society thriving under the



protection of Nüwa, the snake-bodied creator goddess in Chinese legend. She creates humanity from clay and battles mythical beasts. At the bottom shows scenes of primitive people burying the dead with clay pots, which is because the shape of pots resembles the belly of a pregnant woman. In contrast, the second illustrates a patriarchal one, ruled by the emperor. While in the first illustration Nüwa symbolizes protection and creation, here patriarchal rulers command destruction, and snakes are reduced to demonic figures of seduction.

The third image marks major turning points in this transformative process of snake symbolism in China. While snakes were reduced from a powerful goddess to serpent demons, women were also reduced to men's property. The tragedy of the serpent is intertwined with the tragedy of women.

MIMESIS OF ANTIQUITY: REALISM AND MATERIAL ILLUSION IN SONG DYNASTY CELADON CONG

SYDNEY GRAYSON
MCGILL UNIVERSITY

THE FLOURISHING urban economy and evolving cultural landscape of the Song dynasty bolstered a groundbreaking period of ceramic innovation, driven in part by the unique aesthetic pursuits of an expanding scholar-official class. Artistic ingenuity during this time drew not only from contemporary technological advancements but also from the rich reservoir of China's ancient past. Among the most revered materials in traditional Chinese culture, jade held enduring symbolic significance—its translucency, texture, and noble associations made it an emblem of elite taste. As a result, porcelain, particularly celadon ware, with its delicate glaze and jade-like warmth, came to embody these revered qualities in a new material form. Within this context, ceramic vessels modeled after ancient jade cong—cylindrical, ritualistic artifacts from Neolithic China—emerge as particularly compelling: they occupy a curious space between replication and reinvention, where ancient forms are not simply imitated but reimagined in a progressive historical and cultural moment.

Cong-shaped celadon vessels are not faithful reproductions of Neolithic jade artifacts but transformative works that construct a new kind of realism grounded in materiality, affective experience, and metaphor. Through the lens of mimesis, these ceramics evoke the symbolic weight of ancient jade while asserting a new identity through the affordances of the ceramic medium. Rather than striving for historical accuracy, Song potters and antiquarians redefined antiquity as an aesthetic and phenomenological construct, using ceramics to materialize cultural pasts in a form that aligned with contemporary values.

The Song Dynasty in China—which spanned over three centuries, from 960 to 1279—was a remarkable cultural epoch, characterized by immense technological, scientific, philosophical, and economic growth and transformation, leading to the rise of a large urban commercial class and a scholar-official elite. These literati furthered an intellectual reformation known as Neo-Confucianism, which championed the seemingly traditional values and practices of Confucianism while critiquing dominant Daoist and Buddhist outlooks. However, it still borrowed much of their philosophy, including self-cultivation practices like meditation, and the principal notion of li, the organic ordering of nature.

The dynasty is typically divided into Northern and Southern periods, as military struggles on the northern border led to the imperial family's relocation to a new southern capital, today's Hangzhou, in 1127. The combination of Neo-Confucianism and the fall of the northern capital prompted a retrospective look at China's past in the Southern Song period—materially, within the economic demands of a new urban class, and in the realm of ancestral traditions and ideals.

As part of efforts to revive past values, the collection of antiquities blossomed, as the objects were believed to transmit the virtues and ideals to their present-day owners.[1] Illustrated catalogs of such collections were published, allowing contemporary artists to reproduce and draw inspiration from archaic forms. However, Southern Song antiquarianism was less concerned with historical accuracy than with curating a usable past. These objects, primarily ritual jades and bronzes, were valued

1 Jessica Rawson, Chinese Jade: From the Neolithic to the Qing (British Museum Press, 1995), 88.

FIGURE 1. CONG, NEOLITHIC PERIOD, LIANGZHU CULTURE, C. 2500 BC, DARK GREY-GREEN AND BROWN OPAQUE STONE, HIGHLY POLISHED, HEIGHT 23.3 CM, WIDTH 8.2 CM. PUBLISHED: RAWSON 1995, FIG 3:5.

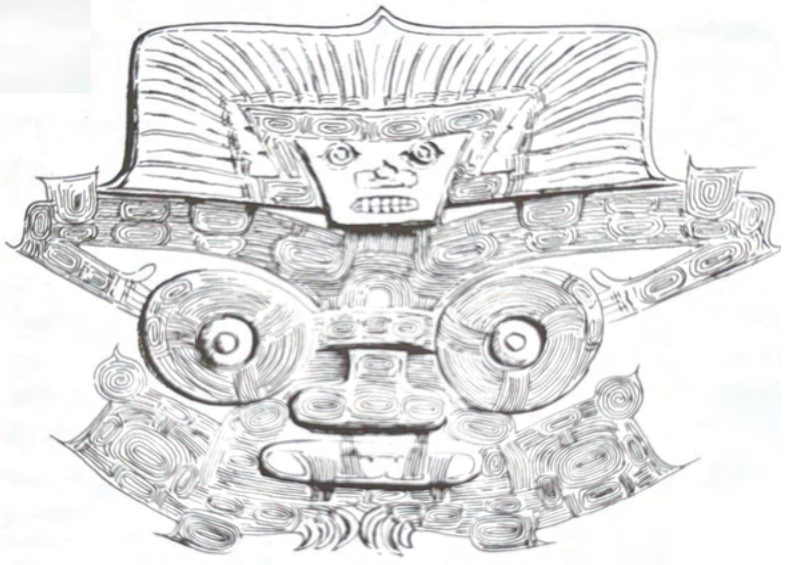


FIGURE 2. DRAWING OF A DESIGN OF A MAN-LIKE FIGURE AND A MONSTER ON A CONG FROM ZHEJIANG YUHANG FANSHAN. AFTER WENWU 1988.1, PP. 1–31, FIG 20.

less for their original functions and more for the abstract ideals they were thought to embody—Neo-Confucian principles that could be woven into the cultural and political fabric of the present. In contrast to earlier appropriations of Neolithic forms in the Zhou and Han dynasties, the Song diverged in its use of these pieces. As the art historian Jessica Rawson notes in her comprehensive study of jade, even when Song scholars knew the particular function of an artifact, they "completely ignored these uses" and attached new associations to ancient vessel shapes in their reproductions—for example, adapting a ritualistic bronze cauldron into an incense burner.[2] Although the theoretical foundations and proper associates of such objects were recorded in texts, the link between later copies and their historical functions was loose. This suggests that what was most important to Song collectors and intellectuals was the ways in which the present could benefit from the past.

The practice of imitation in ceramics is observed in both official kilns—those under royal control for exclusive purposes—and folk kilns, which were locally owned and aimed at broader market demands. Folk kilns were often guided by the production of official kilns, as those became the most sought-after in their exclusivity, but were less restricted and could incorporate wider artistic expressions. Here, jade's aesthetic and cultural value comes to the fore, as elite adoration for celadon glaze, renowned for its remarkable jade-like color and texture, accelerated celadon production across society, beyond official kilns. In his famous book The Classic of Tea (c. 760 CE), Lu Yu praised the "porcelain of the Yuezhou (越州) kilns," among the earliest producers of celadon, as the best because it is "like jade" and "like ice," clean and pure.[3] This reverence for jade paralleled longstanding traditions of jade worship in China, where the stone was utilized for ceremonial and ritual contexts and was imbued with spiritual significance.

Jade, which in scholarly literature refers most often to nephrite, is incredibly tough and durable. Its color and texture are enduringly appealing, and the stone takes on a translucent, sensual quality when polished. These properties made jade highly valued in ancient religious practices as well as in later periods, where it became an important metaphor for describing the qualities expected in powerful, virtuous men. A well-known passage, attributed to Confucius, illustrates the stone's symbolism: "Anciently superior men found the likeness of all excellent qualities in jade"—benevolence in its smoothness, intelligence in its strength and good faith in its internal radiance. Such eminent men found themselves "esteemed by all under the sky, like the path of truth and duty."[4] The visible qualities of jade objects, like texture, color, decoration, and carving, were thus tied to their invisible qualities, including reference, function, and cultural context. As natural jade became increasingly scarce, material substitutes became commonplace, propelling the advancement of ceramic technology. By the ninth and tenth centuries, potters began producing glazes that replicated jade's qualities.[5] As Rawson notes, when an object's "visible qualities change, so do the invisible associations." The Song-era repurposing and adaptation of jade's moral connotations and cultural symbolism evince this dynamic.

Jade production dates to around 4,000 BC, when Neolithic communities crafted objects from the stone for elite burial and ritual use. One such culture, the Liangzhu (ca. 2,500 BC), is particularly known for producing jade works with rectangular exteriors and circular interiors—congs (fig. 1). While the exact meaning and function of these impressive works remain almost entirely unknown, Rawson highlights the diverse historical customs and uses associated with the cong, such as their arrangement

2 Ibid., 90.
3 Lili Fang, The History of Chinese Ceramics (Springer Nature, 2023), 511.
4 Quoted in Rawson, Chinese Jade, 13.
5 Jenny F. So, "Jade," in The Encyclopedia of Ancient History: Asia and Africa (Wiley-Blackwell, 2020), 5.

in burial settings alongside other ritual objects, suggesting a range of possible meanings.[6] As seen in figure 1, square-sectioned cong of this size were typically decorated with an archaic face pattern spanning their corners. The design in its full complexity is an amalgam of a man-like figure and a strange beast, illustrated clearly in a drawing Rawson showcases from one of the largest cong found in Jiangsu (fig. 2).

Jade, one of the toughest stones to work with, could not be carved using regular metal tools. To form the ridges featured on most cong, artisans had to wear down the mineral using abrasive pastes made with stronger stones.[7] It follows that the faces of this complex motif were often abbreviated, typically rendered with simple circles on each corner to denote eyes (fig. 1) or even further simplified into linear elements suggesting a creature's nose and a man's headband. As the Liangzhu culture declined and the expertly crafted cong gradually disappeared, their physical and symbolic meanings likewise faded. However, their forms nonetheless endured, ready for reinterpretation in a new material medium.

Archaic bronze and jade replications from the Song Dynasty are found more frequently from the folk kilns of Longquan in the Lishui prefecture than from any other region. These include many of the best examples of cong-shaped ceramics, such as one held in the British Museum (fig. 3). These vessels consist of a circular mouth and base attached to a molded square body that is rounded on the inside, with protruding straight lines on all four sides. Unlike their jade predecessors, these cong are not hollow throughout and have a sealed bottom. This form is an essential specification for their use in contemporary times as functional altar or study vases, typically filled with water and flowers.[8] These vases are less attenuated than the ancient jade cong—their walls are vertically straight rather than slightly inclined, and they are broader relative to their height. The archaic man-and-monster motif is further abstracted from its Neolithic jade ancestors, reduced to horizontal flanges along the corners, usually arranged in eight sections, with no eye indentations or other figural details. Rather than suggesting crude craftsmanship, these abbreviated designs reflect a conscious reinterpretation of motif in line with Neo-Confucian intellectual and aesthetic values.

Through the influence of Song scholars and officials, Neo-Confucianism rose to prominence as a means of preserving and restoring the cultural heritage of China. Scholar Lili Fang notes how it has been described as "Confucianism on the outside and Taoism on the inside."[9] These two philosophical schools have significantly impacted the aesthetics of Chinese ceramics throughout history. Compared to Confucianism's emphasis on tradition and social order, Daoism advocates for harmony with nature, promoting a simple and restrained aesthetic style that highlights natural beauty.[10] In the Daodejing, the Daoist founder Laozi expresses his admiration for jade, much like Confucius did. "Not only is the Sage hidden, but he also hides great treasures within," Laozi writes. "This is why the Sage wears coarse cloth, but inside it he embraces jade."[11] Here, jade embodies an essential quality one should strive to cultivate internally. In the case of the cong vases, their shape and motif, as copies of ancient ritual objects, align with prevalent Confucian ideas that favored tradition and custom, while their mellow, jade-like color, smoothness, and simplified face motif evoke a disciplined, Daoist sensibility. The ceramic medium, adapted proportions, and philosophical refinement of the Longquan cong support Yunchiahn Sena's claim that "stylistic appropriation

6 Rawson, Chinese Jade, 123.
7 So, "Jade," 1.
8 S. J. Vainker, Chinese Pottery and Porcelain: From Prehistory to the Present (George Braziller, 1991), 110.
9 Fang, The History of Chinese Ceramics, 510.
10 Yijun Dai, "Oriental Aesthetics and the Design of Longquan Celadon," International Journal of Design Science vol. 2, no. 1 (March 2022), 31.
11 Laozi quoted in Thomas Michael, In the Shadows of the Dao: Laozi, the Sage, and the Daodejing (State University of New York Press, 2015), ProQuest Ebook Central, 12.

FIGURE 3. VASE, 1127-1279, CELADON-GLAZED PORCELAIN, LONGQUAN (TOWN), THE BRITISH MUSEUM. HTTPS://WWW.BRITISHMUSEUM.ORG/COLLECTION/OBJECT/A_1947-0712-126?SELECTEDIMAGEID=32962001

FIGURE 4. FLOWER VASE IN THE SHAPE OF A “CONG” RITUAL VESSEL, SOUTHERN SONG DYNASTY, 12TH–13TH CENTURY, STONEWARE WITH CELADON GLAZE, GUAN WARE, CHINA, TOKYO NATIONAL MUSEUM. HTTPS://WWW.TNM.JP/MODULES/R_COLLECTION/INDEX.PHP?CONTROLLER=DTL&COLID=TG2167&LANG=EN

among archaistic objects in the Southern Song transcended the boundaries of material, vessel type, and décor."[12]

Although numerous examples have been located from Longquan, one notable ceramic cong is attributed to the famous official Guan kiln in the Tokyo National Museum (fig. 5). These wares are closely related to those of Longquan, as the folk potters have been shown to model their pieces on official Guan wares. In fact, the Southern Song court's urgent need for makeshift ritual vessels following the fall of the Northern capital significantly contributed to the widespread popularization and commercialization of ancient imitations.[13] The scholar-official Zhao Yanwei wrote about the esteem of the Guan kilns in his 1206 work Yun Lu Man Zhao, noting that "recently, Linan [the new Southern Song capital; today's Hangzhou] itself has a greenware kiln whose products are superior both to Yue and to Longquan wares."[14] Unlike the greener and thoroughly uniform relatives, Guan ceramics were greatly prized for their grey-blue glaze and intentionally broad glaze crackles, as seen in figure 4. This appearance—or their copies from Longquan—was the preference of the imperial court, rather than the unique style of Longquan pottery. Curator S. J. Vainker suggests that this preference arose because emperors "preferred ceramics for their own sake," while the archaic incense burners, tripods, and cong forms produced predominantly at Longquan were made for the educated elite who valued their reference, but were barred from enjoying official wares.[15] The Guan-style cong in the Tokyo National Museum thus offers a rare and curious example of an official kiln producing a porcelain replacement for a ritual object in its preferred style. Whether or not this official model drove the Longquan kilns, it is clear that the wares display a distinct literati aesthetic of their own.

In the age of Song connoisseurship, there was no longer a need for functioning ritualistic jades of antiquity. By collecting and creating a market for imitative cong vessels, antiquarians and intellectuals strategically leveraged the material's "invisible associations" with power, elite status, and cultural esteem for their own social and political pursuits. Neither medium nor functional realism had any bearing on an antiquity that had been redefined as an aesthetic and phenomenological construct and not a direct historical callback. In this light, imitation can be understood as a distinct form of Song Dynasty "mimesis." As the philosopher Michael Kelly observes, mimesis is a broad term with a myriad of possible meanings as it "moves with history and takes on forms appropriate to each historical period."[16] In the Western philosophical tradition, figures like Plato and Aristotle described mimesis as the representation of nature. Plato stressed aspects of appearance and illusion in mimesis, remaining skeptical and critical of its role in aesthetics. Aristotle's conception of mimesis, while building on his teacher's, uniquely valued mimesis as a means of recreating, even idealizing, existing objects. Aristotle also embraces the creative changes introduced in the process of imitation. As though it were following his ideal, Song pottery displays its own improvisation, abstraction, and transformation of the cong object to best suit its historical climate. A comparable social integration of mimesis appears in the European Middle Ages through the concept of imitatio, the pursuit of emulating Christ's life. Yet while that tradition is modeled after a divine God figure, the "supreme object of imitation," Song ceramics mimesis draws its strongest inspiration from a spiritual sense of nature and a glorified past.[17] Mimesis in cong celadon circumstances operates not only on a formal level but through the sensory experience of the

12 Yunchiahn C. Sena, Bronze and Stone: The Cult of Antiquity in Song Dynasty China (University Of Washington Press, 2019),127.
13 Sena, Bronze and Stone, 149.
14 Vainker, Chinese Pottery and Porcelain, 108.
15 Ibid., 111.
16 Michael Kelly, "Mimesis," in Encyclopedia of Aesthetics (Oxford University Press, 2014).
17 Ibid.

object as well—a combination, then, of its look, feel, and embedded ancestral presence.

By shirking objective replication, cong celadon ceramics construct a sensory-based realism, rooted in the affective experience of the material. Beyond shape, another crucial aspect of their materiality lies in the experiential complexity of the glazed surface. The affordances of the ceramic medium and new glaze technologies allowed Song potters to manipulate both form and surface to evoke jade's essence and its associations. To achieve the distinctive jade-like beauty of celadon, Longquan artisans replaced lime (calcium) glaze material with a lime-alkali (calcium potassium) blend, resulting in a more viscous glaze capable of withstanding high firing temperatures without bleeding.[18] This innovation produced a rich, solid glaze with a soft and lustrous quality, rather than the thin, glassy appearance of earlier lime glazes. In a study of comparable Guan ware shards, Nigel Wood and He Li note that the opacity of the glaze owes much to the complex microstructures formed during firing—specifically, layers of trapped bubbles that closely resemble the visual depth and texture of jade.[19]

These advancements also enabled potters to increase the amount of glaze application, yielding a thick yet translucent finish that pools delicately to give textured and adorned surfaces vibrant accents. The thorough melding of the body and glaze represents another technological change that Southern Song Longquan potters embraced. Increasing the firing temperature in the kiln creates a stronger reduction atmosphere. In reduction-firing, oxygen flow is restricted, causing chemical alterations that result in distinctive hues and visual effects that further benefit the refined texture of celadon pieces when properly executed.[20] Finally, as with Guan ware techniques, multilayered glaze application also helped to mask the slightly coarser, more iron-rich clays being used for the bodies.[21] That said, Longquan stoneware were already a pale, light grey and did not have to go to great lengths to disguise dark or coarser clay through glaze. The resulting quality was so high that Western writers remark they have "long been regarded as porcelains."[22] In Western terminology, celadon would be defined as stoneware rather than porcelain, as the clay body is not purely white nor translucent. However, in the Chinese classification, they count as porcelain, as the term includes "high-fired ceramics with a wide range of visual properties."[23]

By skillfully representing jade's visual and tactile qualities while fundamentally presenting as a different material—glazed ceramic—cong-shaped vessels enact a form of mimesis that surpasses imitation and is more akin to transformation. This interplay of presentation and representation creates what Jonathan Hay describes as "metaphoric space."[24] In this conceptual field, the celadon surface assumes jade's associative qualities—antiquity, power, and virtuosity—generating layered symbolic meaning for the ceramics. Additionally, the functional reinterpretation and formal transformation of the cong into a vase reveals how Song elites consumed antiquity as a metaphor for their own ideals. The value of the object lies not only in its material mimesis of a higher-status material but in its translational capacity to evoke jade's nature and status while asserting a distinct material

18 Fang, The History of Chinese Ceramics, 423-424.

19 Nigel Wood and He Li, "A Study of the Techniques Used to Make Laohudong Guan Ware in China in the Southern Song Dynasty," Archaeometry 57, no. 4 (2014), https://doi.org/10.1111/arcm.12105, 1.

20 Ibid., 3.

21 Ibid., 6.

22 Vainker, Chinese Pottery and Porcelain, 108.

23 Shan Huang et al., "The Path to Porcelain: Innovation in Experimental White Stoneware from Luoyang," Journal of Archaeological Science 158 (October 2023), https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jas.2023.105839, 9.

24 Jonathan Hay, Sensuous Surfaces: The Decorative Object in Early Modern China (University of Hawai' i Press, 2010), 82.

identity. This duality creates what Hay calls a "play of resonance," enabling the viewer to imagine two surfaces, jade and ceramic, at once suspended in a state of simultaneous recognition and transformation.[25]

All physical surfaces, as Hay writes, have their own "immediate affective potential," an inherent capacity to elicit sensory and emotional responses.[26] In the case of jade, its unique surface effect—whether tough, translucent, black, or brown—is derived from its mineral composition. "In the realm of sensory experience," Hay writes, effect generates an affective response. Craft further enhances this potential, through the abrading and polishing of ritual jades, or, in the Song context, through the careful texturing of clay and inventive glaze work. The affective potency of the cong vessel was not only a surface-level technical illusion, but a carrier of cultural value and sign of scholarly contemplation. Hay continues by exploring how an intricately rendered "surfacescape," like the ceramic cong, can provoke sensuous and pleasurable engagement through a recognition of internal complexity.[27] According to Yijun Dai's study of aesthetics in Longquan Celadon, the Song philosopher and poet Zhu Xi conceptualized a comparable idea of "'admiring objects for pleasure' based on the Confucian idea of 'play in arts.'"[28] The mimesis of jade, then, is not mere visual deception but a form of phenomenological realism: a way of engaging with the past, translating its values into a new material register, and inviting literati to contemplate antiquity through affect, metaphor, and form.

The revival of antiquity through ceramic art in China's Song Dynasty reveals a complex network of ideas involving meaning, material, and memory. Celadon vases imitating Neolithic jade cong stand as more than an aesthetic tribute to a distant past—they are instruments of transformative mimeses, privileging sensory realism and metaphorical resonance over historical precision. Shaped by the values of the intellectual class and informed by Neo-Confucian and Daoist philosophies, these vessels offered a new way to relate to the past, one rooted in cultivated reflection rather than ritual function. In redefining the cong's original function, the Song vessels effectively "sealed the loss" of the form's ancient meanings, to borrow Jessica Rawson's phrase.[29] Yet, as Rawson and Yunchiahn Sena argue, Song antiquarianism had less to do with recovering lost practices than reimagining ancient forms to serve contemporary philosophical, aesthetic, and social ends.

The cong vases, with their simplified designs and recontextualized functions, became instruments for scholarly meditation. They celebrated Daoist naturalism and simplicity with their delicate jade-like glazes and harmonious proportions and adhered to Confucian reverence for tradition through their archaic shapes. The celadon's thick, layered glaze, achieved through technical advancements such as lime-alkali mixtures and reduction firing, created optical and tactile illusions that bridged the material and the symbolic. Hay's notion of "metaphoric space" aptly describes this duality, as the ceramics' surfaces simultaneously evoke jade's cultural weight and moral virtues and affirm the material ingenuity of their own ceramic medium. These vessels invite contemporary viewers to move fluidly between past and present, imitation and transformation, reality and illusion.

25 Ibid., 82.
26 Ibid., 78.
27 Ibid., 78.
28 Dai, "Oriental Aesthetics," 31.
29 Rawson, Chinese Jade, 90.

“WINDOW”

2025
COLOR FILM

“WUND

ERKAMMER”

2025
BLACK AND WHITE TRI-X FILM

GRACE BIDA

HARVARD UNIVERSITY

Photography for me is an evolving practice of empathy, inquiry, and deep seeing. Over time I’ve learned that the camera is not a shield but a bridge that draws me closer to the tensions, textures, and windows into everyday life. My process begins with an open curiosity: I wander, pause, and allow myself to look and see. I aim for each image to become a conversation with my surroundings, with my own attention, and with unseen stories waiting to be acknowledged.

Sydney Suh

University of California Los Angeles

I Left 1/9 of my Grief in Canada is a video and sound installation, consisting of two sets of nine images and an overlaid short film played via a projector. Over the course of several months, I collected scans and videos of natural-found objects and phenomena, such as plants, shadows, and refractions of light. Drawing upon Caspar David Friedrich's early nineteenth-century landscapes, this serves as a contemporary evocation of the Romantic-era notion of the sublime. It is rooted in discrete observation, understanding nature to be the same awe-inspiring force that allowed for Friedrich's omnipotent depictions of its grandeur to enable even simple occurrences, such as the visuals produced by wind or ripples in puddles on a walk home. From an ideological perspec-

The lamp on your nightstand has small creatures lined inside it

I Left 1/9 of my 2025 Grief in Canada

Digitally manipulated original video, projector, digital photographs, recorded sound

tive, however, this work emphasizes the significance of revision. The majority of the aspects in this piece were completed, redone entirely, edited, and sometimes redone again. In my consistent re-visiting of them, I have come to learn that these found fragments I selected for observation were not just mine, but rather something I shared with the sublime, leading me to the conclusion that there was some other force aiding in a method of non-arbitary co-creation.

Windows to the Soul

Daniel Dumontet
Yale University

"Suddenly,
on the opposite shore,
from under the roof
of the synagogue,
smoke springs.
As if one heard the cries
of burning scrolls
of the Torah
and the altar.

The windows break"

– Marc Chagall[1]

Exterior View of Synagogue Windows

IN ONE OF THE LAST GREAT works of his life, Marc Chagall brought to life – in the form of a dozen monumental windows – the Twelve Tribes of Israel. Installed in 1962 in the synagogue at the Hadassah Medical Center, Jerusalem's flagship hospital, the brilliant riot of reds, yellows, blues, and greens bathe worshippers in the light of unity. Born in 1887 in a rural town outside Russian Vitebsk, Moyshe Shagal – later, Marc Chagall – lived through violent pogroms during his childhood and fled Nazi persecution as an adult[2]. The tragic beauty of his life and work culminated in the Hadassah windows. Created by a complicated and fractured soul, the Hadassah windows speak for a generation and inspire the next by capturing the healing and hopes of a single artist – and, by extension, of an entire people and their state.

The enormous arched windows dominate the synagogue, each measuring 8'x11' and depicting, in larger-than-life scale, the tribes which the patriarch Jacob's twelve sons founded. Each panel is replete with symbols of its respective tribe – Issachar's donkey, Zebulun's boat, Joseph's vines of plenty. The synagogue's architecture is designed around the windows; simple lines, minimal decoration, restrained internal lighting, and seats circling the central bimah draw the eye upward to the vibrant panels, erected overhead like an incandescent, rainbow crown[3].

1 Allyn Weisstein. "Iconography of Chagall," The Kenyon Review 16, no. 1 (Winter, 1954): 43

2 Ines Schlenker. "Masters of Art: Chagall," Prestel Penguin Random House Verlagsgruppe, (2022): 10

3 "Chagall: The Jerusalem Windows." The Museum of Modern Art, (1961): 1

From Left to Right: Reuben, Simeon, Levi Windows

The synagogue serves the Hadassah hospital. Founded as a Zionist institution to serve both Jews and Arabs, the original hospital predates Israeli independence, with its first campus located at Mount Scopus less than two miles northeast of Jerusalem's Old City. However, in the aftermath of the 1948 Israeli War of Independence, the land surrounding Mount Scopus was annexed by Jordan, and so the hospital, an inaccessible Israeli exclave, was abandoned. Years later, a new campus was built in 1961, this time out of reach of hostile forces almost five miles due west of the Old City[4]. During construction, hospital officials commissioned Chagall to bring his special light to Jerusalem's new flagship medical center[5]. The Hadassah windows were born from conflict, engaging in poignant conversation with the medical center's healing role and the active regional tension.

Especially in light of this conflict, the overwhelming message of the Hadassah windows is that of unity. The Twelve Tribes of Israel flourished under kings Saul, David, and Solomon, who united, defended, and developed the Kingdom of Israel (with Jerusalem as its capital)[6]. Each tribe's window depicts a different aspect of their kingdom; the Old City in Judah's window; the hilly countryside in Levi's; the Mediterranean coast in Reuben's; and an intimate domestic scene in Asher's. Together, the windows capture the depth and spirit of both Jerusalem and the entirety of the Holy Land.

All Twelve Tribes have their own, equally-sized panels; none dominates another. Their individual strengths are preserved,

4 "Hadassah: Medical Excellence in the First Hospital that was Nominated for the Nobel Peace Prize" Hadassah International, June 11, 2018, https://hadassahinternational.org/hadassah-medical-excellence-in-the-first-hospital-that-was-nominated-for-the-nobel-peace-prize/

5 MOMA, "Jerusalem Windows," 1

6 J. Coert Rylaarsdam. "David," Encyclopedia Britannica 2024)

and yet their lantern-like arrangement means one cannot stand without the other. The medium extends this metaphor; each strip of cut glass, each layer of chemical 'paint' retains its particular vibrancy, and yet the greater panels are born from these fused individuals. Chagall's direct promotion of Jewish unity radiates diverse strength. Jews can preserve their distinct cultures and backgrounds. And, gathered in this modern hospital – a place of regrowth in the historic Holy Land – they are one in a common nation and peoplehood.

Before exploring what other messages the windows communicate, it's important here to note that Chagall at one point repudiated any direct explanation of his work, once vehemently arguing:

"I don't understand [my work] at all… The theories which I would make up to explain myself and those which others elaborate in connection with my work are nonsense… My paintings are my reason for existence, my life and that's all"[7]

He said this years before the Hadassah windows. Still, even here Chagall is conscious that his paintings are him – paintings which speak to his soul even when he cannot put words to what they're saying. Yet years later, in his speech at the inauguration of the Hadassah synagogue he said:

Dan Window Model

"...It seems to me that colors and lines flow like tears from my eyes, even though I am not crying… the older I get the more I know what I want and the more I know what I am saying"[8]

Throughout the interim between these two quotes, the spiritual origins of his creativity never changed. As we'll soon see he remained the ailing, searching soul for all his life. However, the creation of the Hadassah windows helped elucidate his artistic purpose; his view of the universe, if not of himself. Especially in such a forum as a synagogue, it's therefore reasonably within the observer's liberty to read between the lines, or between the panes, and to interpret the windows' biblical messages – if not as Chagall's overt intention, then as they affect both the nation and the individual.

7 Daniel E. Schneider. "A Psychoanalytic Approach to the Painting of Marc Chagall," *College Art Journal* 6, no. (Winter, 1946): 116

8 Marc Chagall. "Inaugural speech by Marc Chagall," *Transcript of speech delivered at Hadassah Medical Center Jerusalem*, (February 6, 1962) (translated from the original French by Gilbert Dumontet)

Chagall was inspired by Genesis 49, where Jacob blesses his twelve sons, and by Deuteronomy 33[9], where Moses blesses the Tribes (Hebrew text from these chapters is included in the windows[10]). Looking at these chapters, he seems to inject into the windows advice for the nation. Therein lies a particular beauty of the Hadassah windows – as we'll see in the end, that everyone brings their own light to the windows, and so anyone can derive personalized lessons from them.

This is my interpretation of a few of the countless possible lessons and national values, gleaned from the windows, that Israel – any country, for that matter – ought to embrace:

"Dan shall judge his people as one of the tribes of Israel… [he shall be] a viper along the path, that bites the horse's heels so that its rider falls backward"[11]

In Dan's window, the scales of justice balance candles; illuminated by their light, Jerusalem in the background shines pure white. But, should the candelabra be extinguished, armed equines stand ready – whether they're on the side of good or evil is unclear. The absence of judgment is darkness and uncertainty; Israel ought to be its own viper, exercising judicious decision-making in order to preclude chaos and promote stability. Here he embraces avant garde color palettes over expected combinations; and he replaces heavy-handed moralizing with abstract messaging appropriate to his modern era. Chagall repudiates centuries of stained glass tradition while revolutionizing the same techniques which have inspired countless millions. In doing so he forges a new tool to interrogate the relationship between personal, communal, and global upheaval.

"Rejoice, Zebulun, in your going out… [you] suck the affluence of the seas and the hidden treasures of the sand"[12]

Zebulun Window

Zebulun's boat returns to shore with the day's catch, its green sail propelling it through the fiery red sea at sunset. The tribe innovates and finds valuable resources (fish) in the ocean; Israel, though lacking significant oil fields compared to its neighbors[13], can create its own abun-

9 MOMA, "Jerusalem Windows," 1
10 "Chagall's iconic windows at the Hadassah Hospital in Jerusalem," Public Delivery, October 2, 2024, https://publicdelivery.org/chagall-jerusalem-windows/
11 Genesis 49:16-17
12 Deuteronomy 33:18-19
13 "Israel Science & Technology: Oil & Natural Gas," Jew-

dance if it finds economic opportunities in areas overlooked by most. The boat's undeniable momentum towards an unseen shore; its unabashed contrast with the very waters on which it glides; this compositional tension – this national struggle – transforms deficiency into energy and difference into strength.

"Issachar is a strong donkey… he saw that the land was pleasant; so he bowed his shoulder to the burden, and became a slave at forced labor"[14]

Issachar's donkey luxuriates in a field of green, his purplish belly full. The whole of Jerusalem is verdant and peaceful.

Yet hostile serpents lurk in the margins,

L-R: Judah, Zebulun, Issachar

ready to pounce; and the Ten Commandments hide behind Mount Sinai, the path blocked by God's hands. In their quest for truth and enlightenment (represented by the Commandments), a people cannot stagnate or risk becoming a victim of complacency and subject to others' rule. A doctor who hasn't slept in days; a patient undergoing another major operation; a beleaguered nation seemingly constantly on the brink of war. Light – representing the responsibility to preserve life – can be heavy. The way out (or better: through) isn't obvious or easy; the windows aren't on ground-level and require an active effort to see. But once one chooses to appreciate their beauty, chooses to help support a literal and moral structure which already 'floats' on its own, that weight is lifted. And Issachar's "burden" to life becomes a mission, an aspiration, an inspiration.

"[Judah] stretches out like a lion… the scepter shall not depart from Judah… [until] the obedience of the peoples is his"[15]

Though his tired eye is downcast, Judah's lion (which anthropomorphically wears a kippah) sits in front of Jerusalem, protecting his kingdom. In a royal red sky, the luminous hands of God raise to heaven the crown of King David (descendant of Judah). The Jewish people, as ordained by God, are a sovereign nation. Yet today they must remain united – as under David – to secure and perpetuate their independence. Passionate

ish Virtual Library, 2024, https://jewishvirtuallibrary.org/oil-and-natural-gas-in-israel

14 Genesis 49:14-15

15 Genesis 49:9-10

colors encourage active pursuit of what ought to be a heartfelt mission. And the clear messaging, perhaps the most overt of all its neighbors, exhorts sincerity and vigilance in this generational struggle.

These are a few lessons for the nation that the Hadassah windows convey. What about lessons for the individual? To understand what an observer might derive from them, it's necessary to look at the evolution of the artist and how the windows impacted Chagall himself. Luckily – tragically – his White Crucifixion (1938)[16], painted just one year before the outbreak of World War II, provides the perfect case-study.

White Crucifixion is almost pure chaos. Peasants and rabbis alike weep; a village (Jerusalem? Chagall's native Vitebsk? Both.) burns in the background; Judas absconds with his silver[17]. The most important element isn't one of these tragic characters, or even God's blinding light which floods the piece and saves Christ. The most telling detail is a boat in the midground. A boat full of refugees.

Stylistically speaking, White Crucifixion could easily be mapped onto stained glass and fit in with the Hadassah windows (or the windows painted, and fit in with White Crucifixion). These are more than a hallmark of Chagall's distinct, anachronistic hand[18]; their stylistic proximity blends modern pogroms with biblical narratives. With dejection, the refugees – exiled from the Holy Land – find a new home in Europe. Simultaneously (and with a desperate hope), the same refugees (contemporary European Jews) flee this new European home which has turned on them, seeking safety in those familiar ancient shores.

By 1938, Chagall – who wasn't practicing Judaism[19] and who was safe in France with an assured ticket of escape to New York[20] – is more than distraught; the traumas of his childhood in Russia, his relationship with Judaism, and his utter lack of power come to a head in this telling piece.

Contrast this with the joy and strength felt in the Hadassah windows, created just over 20 years later. In his own words:

"[The windows] have completely trans-

16 Weisstein, "Iconography," 40-41

17 Ibid, 40-41

18 Ibid, 43-44

19 Revd Jonathan Evens. "Marc Chagall's Exquisit Stained Glass Window Commissions," *Artlyst* (May 17, 2021)

20 Schlenker, "Masters of Art: Chagall," 32

formed my vision, they gave me a great shock, made me reflect. I don't know how I shall paint from now on, but I believe something is taking place"[21]

Napthali Detail

A transformation. Perhaps the Hadassah windows helped him process survivor's guilt. Undoubtedly stained glass (a new medium that Chagall only picked up after World War II) provided a new creative outlet for the artist, whom many criticized as artistically stagnating[22]. Yet the major glass projects he completed before Hadassah – which include commissions for the Metz Cathedral[23] which drew upon his famous depictions of Christ – didn't change him. These familiar subjects, this new medium, weren't enough. He needed more. He needed the uniquely visceral experience of creating the windows not just for any religious setting, but specifically to celebrate the newly independent Israel, which played an essential role in Chagall's healing.

To explore this, let's look at why Chagall was commissioned to make the windows. One possible reason he was chosen was his worldwide fame, which garnered international support (or recognition, at least) for both the hospital and the state, thereby promoting cultural diplomacy. Whether intended or not, the Hadassah windows made international headlines and were a worldwide success. After the windows drew hundreds of thousands of visitors at their pre-installation exhibitions at both the Louvre and Museum of Modern Art in New York[24], President John F. Kennedy remarked in a publicized telegram to Hadassah officials:

"[The windows are] extraordinary… The inspiration of an ancient and noble history and the inspiration of modern artistic genius are combined in these windows… by their beauty they will serve and encourage the scientific and humanitarian work done there"[25]

Here, the windows are a powerful political tool; through his celebratory praise of the windows, Kennedy alludes to and reaffirms America's support of Israel's

21 Alfred Werner. "Chagall's Jerusalem Windows," *Art Journal* 21, no. 4 (Summer, 1962): 226
22 Schlenker. "Masters of Art: Chagall," 36
23 Evens, "Commissions"
24 Werner, "Jerusalem Windows," 224
25 MOMA, "Jerusalem Windows," 2

ancestral and modern claims to national sovereignty, promoting the reborn state among Americans and allied nations even as Israel continued to face hostility from its neighbors[26]. Yet the windows weren't primarily commissioned for foreign nations to express their socio-political support, nor to sway international opinions one way or another. Had they been purely diplomatic tools as such, wouldn't it have been more effective to place them in a central civic monument instead of a quiet (if historic) hospital? The windows are tailored to a people while remaining purposefully abstract. Chagall was chosen for this specific hospital setting because he spoke to the Jewish people; because he spoke for a broken generation in need of healing; and because he gave voice to the Jewish vision for this regeneration of a nation.

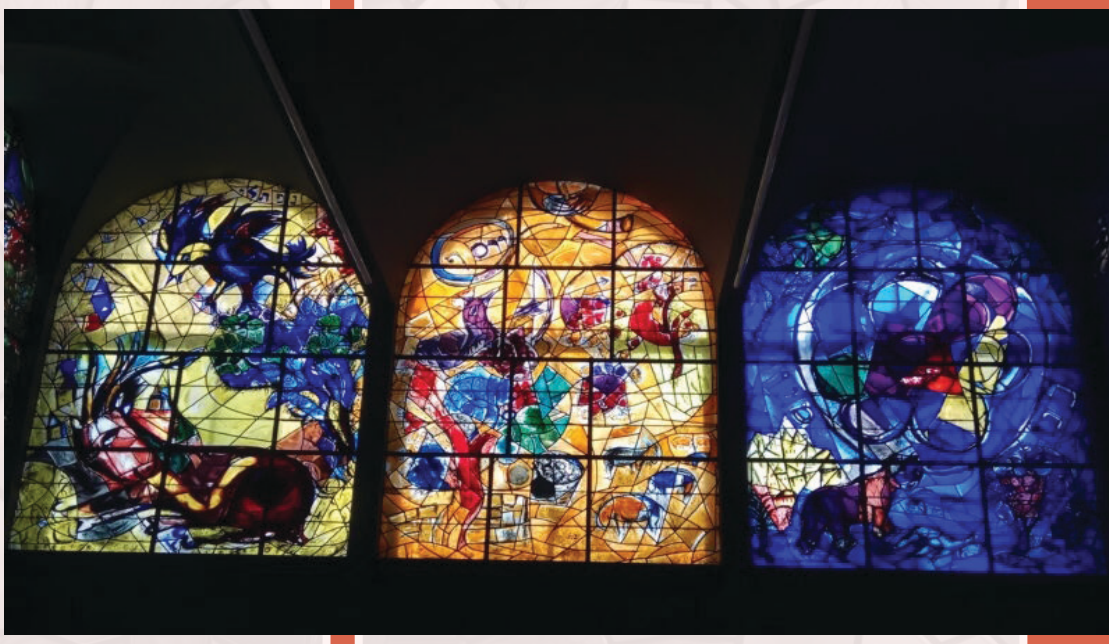
This idea of an ancestral Jewish home calls to Chagall. It also haunts him. He was always acutely aware of how his lived experiences, his family history, and his artwork (colors, themes, symbols) connect both to ancient and modern Jewish history[27]. Once he said of the colors and stories behind his paintings:

"Sometimes, the wine in Father's glass seemed to me even more red. It reflected a deep lilac, royal, the "ghetto" traced for the Jewish people, and the ardor of the Arabian desert, crossed with so much pain"[28]

Chagall blends intergenerational, biblical stories with his lived history in a series of motifs – flying lovers, bouquets of flowers, anthropomorphic farm animals, and music. Early on, these elements were a way for Chagall to process conflicting elements of his childhood:

"...my uncle plays the violin. He who all day leads the cows from the stable, dragging them and tying their legs – plays now, plays the song of the rabbi"[29]

He struggled to reconcile the death his uncle inflicted as a butcher with the joy he created when playing religious music.



L-R: Naphtali, Joseph, Benjamin

26 "Arab-Israeli wars." Britannica, October 30, 2024, https://www.britannica.com/event/Arab-Israeli-wars

27 Schneider, "Psychoanalytic," 121

28 Weisstein, "Iconography," 42

29 Ibid, 46

Joseph Window

One way he explores this tension with Judaism is by painting farm animals playing the violin[30], mixing their short-lived time on Earth (bluntly put, cows and chickens are kept to be eaten) with the timeless songs of his ancestors. Many have tried to explain these violent crashes of elements. But when we remember that Chagall himself failed to ascribe a single, let alone linear explanation to his own work, it becomes clear that it's the search for meaning itself which most valuably elucidates his arcane creations.

Unexpectedly, these hyper-specific motifs, found across his oeuvre, take a backseat in the Hadassah windows. Yet their tension can still be found across the panels – in the harmony of Levi's window, where beasts and birds dance as one in a brilliant field of gold, beneath the anachronistic Magen David (a newly adopted symbol of Zionism[31]); and in the discord of Gad's window, where ambiguous avian and anthropomorphic tetrapods fade into the green background as they take up sword and spear to fight one another. Why? Because through creating the windows, Chagall works through his traumas and eases the tensions with which he grappled for so many years.

This healing is evidenced by the fact that the windows aren't about him. By injecting subtler versions of his symbols and characters into the windows, he paints himself into a collective history – and a religion with which he always felt disconnected[32]. Meant for the community, Chagall unprecedentedly shifts away from painting composites from his own life to painting religious themes common amongst all Jews. He doesn't make the windows, the synagogue, or the Torah about him, but provides a catalyst for others to find their place. The windows' interpretive subject matter invites introspection, Chagall's stylistic abstraction imploring worshipers to find individual meaning in his brilliantly lit colors and his avant-garde, yet traditional, personal, yet universal motifs.

He's quoted as soon as the early 1930s with saying "The land and the air of the East are impregnated with wisdom"[33]. He has a deep appreciation for, and is influenced by, thousands of years of ancestral history, and yet he feels a dissonance between himself and "this Jewish people"

30 Schneider, "Psychoanalytic," 118

31 "Magen David - Star of David," Jewish Virtual Library, 2007, https://www.britannica.com/event/Arab-Israeli-wars

32 Evens, "Commissions"

33 Werner, "Jerusalem Windows," 228

whose…

"...tragic and heroic resistance movements, in the ghettos, and that your war here, in this country, find themselves mixed together with my flowers, and with the beasts and my fiery colors… [which] shall remain in… your land"[34]

His artwork. Their religion. Even after intimately intertwining his essence with Jewish history, he still finds it impossible to identify with either the concrete state of Israel or the abstract notion of a religious peoplehood. Why does he fail to find belonging within this part of his identity? Perhaps this is a sign that, although he felt connected to his culture, he kept drifting further away from the religious aspects of Judaism[35]. A possible explanation is that Chagall is part of a greater wave of post-war 'secular Judaism'[36] (one which embraced the cultural and philosophical sides of Jewish thought over active worship). Like so many in the generations surrounding the Holocaust, Chagall's confrontations with religion and belief in God seem to have made it difficult to identify with his paradoxically foreign homeland. In his inaugural speech he reflects, even laments:

Marc Chagall Working on the Windows

"How could I have imagined that not only my own hands with their colors were guiding me… but that would also guide me the poor hands of my parents, and of others, and others more with silent lips and eyes shut, who were jostling and whispering behind me as if they also wanted to take part in my life?"[37]

Even here, Chagall feels the weight of generations, of millions murdered a few short years prior. The enormous responsibility of representing them falls on the shoulders of a man whose healing (like so many others) will never be completed. He cries out that he's still lost –

34 Chagall, "Inaugural speech"

35 Schneider, "Psychoanalytic," 122-123

36 The Pluralism Project, "Postwar Judaism," *Harvard University* (2020): 1-2

37 Chagall,"Inaugural speech"

wandering the "Arabian desert"[38] – never to be fully found… and yet he still gives up his colors, his plants, and his animals – amalgamations of his soul – to provide what he can, to produce a "modest present"[39] for the next generations. The Holocaust will never directly afflict those born in the years to come. But, just as stained glass is made up of many smaller panes, the Hadassah windows give voice to the millions who are now voiceless. They serve as witnesses that, once fractured, a soul can be pieced back together. But it can never be made whole again.

In the same way that stained glass is made up of many smaller pieces, the medium of the windows – glass – is also significant. The hospital didn't commission the grand paintings for which Chagall was most famous at the time but instead the medium of glass. Uniquely powerful, yet extremely delicate.

Who visits a hospital synagogue? A pregnant mother; a pre-operation surgeon; a family visiting loved ones; a grieving son. Like Chagall, others look to the turbulent maroons and sparkling ochres to find their own hope and healing. Decades after the hospital's inauguration, Hadassah officials reflected that the windows are "a gift of hope that will remain for future generations to see"[40]. This cannot be dismissed as an obligatory corporate statement – because Chagall didn't just imbue the windows with specific stories, but for over 60 years has provided a fountain of imagination, a space for future generations to find light within themselves and in others, and has provided a luminous canvas upon which they can paint their own, inspired prayers of healing.

Issachar Window

Yet the Hadassah windows themselves do not illuminate; they would be dark without light coming in from the outside. From this lens, the medium engages with the aforementioned post-war 'secular Judaism'. Simeon's window illustrates this. The only son not to receive a blessing, his unforgivable violence and cruelty curses his descendants whom God will "[scatter] in Israel"[41]. In his window, a

38 Weisstein, "Iconography," 42
39 Chagall, "Inaugural speech"
40 "Chagall's Windows: A Source of Light in Dark Times," Hadassah, April 11, 2024, https://www.hadassah.org/story/chagalls-windows-a-source-of-light-in-dark-times
41 Genesis 49:7

Judah Window

moonless night falls, shrouding the Holy Land in a murky, blue-gray haze. Horses and birds, which in other windows come together, turn their heads from one another in division. Simeon's panel yearns for the same brilliant colors with which the others sing. Yet not even daylight makes up for his failings. The world heeded this warning too late; post-war society collided with the confluence of its moral shortcomings. Far from resulting from a lack of faith, this existential chaos plants the seeds of spiritual 'disillusionment' and the ravaging crisis of self which Chagall so poignantly realizes through the windows.

Moses led the Israelites to the Promised Land in spite of his being unable to enter; Chagall – through a religion and artwork that both is and isn't his – helps spirits in search of healing and hope, even if he never fully found those himself. Heeding the warning of Simeon's example, Chagall looks to the Torah for answers:

"I have heard [the prophets'] ancient words… did they not say exactly… how to behave on Earth and which ideals to live by?"[42]

The Hadassah windows guide individuals and nations to righteous action in two ways. First, even if you don't believe in God, you must act in His just spirit; this way, people can use the beautiful colors of their own lives to paint their own brilliant windows. Second, the windows exhort people to stop waiting for the light to come in – they need to discover in themselves the spark of divinity. They need to be the light. One must first realize that they are as essential to this equation as any outside force. Only then can the lessons of both the Torah and history be realized.

But glass is delicate. Easily broken. A window needs lead to secure its panes, needs a structure to provide support against the strongest winds. Without those, it falls and shatters. A people needs a history to tie them together, needs a state providing for their safety. Without these, they perpetually run from persecutors and, as Chagall searched for identity his entire life, run the risk of forgetting who they are.

But there's beauty – even hope – in that fragility; the possibility of life, peace, and prosperity for all who want it. Chagall closes his inaugural speech:

42 Chagall, "Inaugural speech"

Young Marc Chagall

"[This gift is] for this Jewish people who… has dreamed of biblical love, of friendship and of peace among all peoples… who has lived here for millennia before, here, among the other semitic people"[43]

The Hadassah windows, created by a fractured artist for a hospital which is the product of war, are opportunities for cultural diplomacy. In a hopeful call for regional peace, Chagall sees a future in which the windows are just one element of a broader effort towards healing. The windows channel this healing, helping create a world in which agnostic and Hasid, Jew and Arab find mutual understanding in their history and live harmoniously in their differences. But peace balances on a knife's edge, and life is tragically fragile. So individuals and nations, however disparate, must come together – learning to find strength while still letting the light in.

L-R: Dan, Gad, Asher

43 Ibid

“APRICALE!”

2023
COLORED PENCIL
18 IN. X 24 IN.

JOHN JANNOTTA

WASHINGTON UNIVERSITY IN ST. LOUIS

The piece is made with colored pencils and is 18x24 inches. I completed it in September 2023. I find inspiration from the beauty of our world, particularly its natural features combined with great feats of human creation. On a trip with my family, we visited a beautiful 10th-century Italian village nestled in the side of a mountain. I was instantly intrigued by the ancient crooked shacks stacked atop each other that had survived centuries. Originally appearing as a messy cluster of buildings, examining the village closely revealed each structure’s intricacy. The impressive architecture was framed by lush rolling mountains and azure sky. I returned from Italy to my art studio (a basement dorm room without windows), yearning to go back, and started drawing. Referencing a photo I captured, I meticulously etched in every window, chimney, and shutter, every shadow and slant of light. My colored pencils dwindled to nubs. My hand grew numb and cramped and although my fingers ached, I discovered a sense of passion and satisfaction the more time I spent engrossed in the work. After sacrificing 37 colored pencils and devoting over 70 hours, my piece was finished.

The Expression of the Lamb of God: the Adoration of the Mystic Lamb and Restoring Authenticity

Wren Stryker

Pratt Institute

Fig. 1

"Salvation belongs to our God who is seated on the throne, and to the Lamb," Revelation 7:10.

Salvation, the blood pouring from the heart of the redeemed into the chalice. Salvation, held above the meadow not on a throne, but a red altar. This is the *Adoration of the Mystic Lamb,* the iconic panel in the *Ghent Altarpiece* by the van Eyck brothers. It was rendered in oil, begun by Hubert and finished by Jan in 1432. The bleeding lamb stands on the altar, encircled by praising angels with jewel-toned wings (Fig. 1). The baptismal fountain lies on the vertical axis below, the divine dove above, and all around, the holy creatures are approached by prophets, saints, and martyrs (Fig. 2). The van Eyck brothers, who were the first to achieve illusory realism with oil paint, gave the mystic lamb a humanoid expression. They mutated the passive eyes of an ordinary lamb and gave theirs a front-facing gaze; it stares into the viewer beyond the panel. Its lips are high and pursed, its chin rounded (Fig. 3). These are human features, and they are unsettling. By the mid-16th century, artistic preferences had changed; unknown artisans painted over the central figure of the lamb, along with swaths of background. This was a competent retouching, done with high-quality pigments and naturalistic sensibility.[1] The result of the job was a softened lamb, with typical prey-animal eyes, higher-set ears, and a sheepish muzzle (Fig. 4). This face was the one that history knew for centuries, and all the while the altarpiece was celebrated as a masterpiece of European painting. The overpaint remained undiscovered until conservators began removing the green grass surrounding the lamb in 1951, revealing a second set of ears. Still, for decades, the buried lamb hinted at by these ears remained hid-

1 Nina Siegal, "Up Close, There's More to the Ghent Altarpiece Than the Lamb," The New York Times, January 27, 2020, https://www.nytimes.com/2020/01/27/arts/design/mystic-lamb-ghent-altarpiece-van-eyck.html.

den. But in 2019, mounting scientific evidence encouraged removal of the overpaint.[2] The lamb's new face occupies less than three square centimeters of the complex altarpiece, yet it produced an extraordinary response in viewers. For such a well-funded, well-researched, well-documented restoration effort, it was received poorly; to much of the public and some scholars, the lamb's face was

2 Caitlin O'Riordan, "The Cost of Saving Great Works of Art," Emory International Law Review 32, no. 3 (2018): 431, https://scholarlycommons.law.emory.edu/eilr/vol32/iss3/3.

Fig. 2

Fig. 3

Fig. 4

seen as unsettling and unattractive. This disparity—between the scientific and historically-informed decisions of conservator-restorers and the popular preference for the former expression—is indicative of the aesthetic subjectivity that precludes complete objectivity in conservation. Was removing the overpainting necessary? Utilizing the Eyckian lamb as a case study, this paper will examine the complicated value of authenticity in art, and the obligation of art conservators to restore such authenticity.

On January 24, 2020, the restored panels of the *Ghent Altarpiece* were unveiled to a congregation amassed at St. Bavo's Cathedral in Ghent, Belgium. The *Adoration of the Lamb* would receive the most scrutiny. For the first time in centuries, the world looked upon the authentic lamb and met its unnerving gaze; photographs were published online, and upon comparison to its former appearance, people expressed shock. Neatly summarizing the internet's reaction, the *Smithsonian Magazine* described the face as "alarmingly humanoid."[3] The controversial lamb was presented by officials behind the restoration effort, including lead restorer Hélène Dubois. "This is the original sheep of van Eyck, which was painted over by someone else to make it look like a passive animal, and more anatomically correct," Dubois told the *New York Times*. "But this is what van Eyck's intention was. It's nothing bizarre; it's just not what people are used to looking at and perhaps do not expect."[4] Renaissance art historian Koenraad Jonckheere speculated that the lamb's face was overpainted to neutralize the "intense and humanised identification of the lamb into an expressionless animal."[5] The restoration decision itself was made by the Royal Institute for Cultural Heritage (KIK-IRPA), Belgium's authority on art-historical objects, which transgressed public expectations for one of the country's most iconic paintings.

However, it was not only the general public that expressed discomfort with the restoration's result. Described by the *Brussels Times* as experts calling for an end to the "disastrous" restoration of the *Adoration of the Lamb*, Hélène Verougstraete and Jean-Pierre Coppens came forward to express their opposition to the removal of the overpaint.[6] Verougstraete is a professor of art history and scientific analysis of paintings, trained by the KIK-IRPA in restoration (albeit in the 1960s).[7] They describe the restoration as "catastrophic," claiming it was impossible to date the overpainting

3 Katherine J. Wu, "New Research on the Ghent Altarpiece Validates Restorers' Rendering of the Mystic Lamb's Alarmingly Humanoid Face," Smithsonian Magazine, July 31, 2020, https://www.smithsonianmag.com/smart-news/ghent-altarpiece-restorations-reveal-alarmingly-humanoid-face-famous-mystical-lamb-180973846/.

4 Siegal, "More to the Ghent Altarpiece."

5 "Ghent Altarpiece: Lamb's 'Alarmingly Humanoid' Face Surprises Art World," BBC News, January 22, 2020, https://www.bbc.com/news/world-europe-51205614.

6 "Experts Demand Immediate Halt to 'Disastrous' Restoration of Ghent Altarpiece," The Brussels Times, December 21, 2023, https://www.brusselstimes.com/847289/experts-demand-immediate-halt-to-disastrous-restoration-of-ghent-altarpiece.

7 Hélène Verougstraete, "The Catastrophic Restoration of Phase 2," Closer to Van Eyck, accessed March 24, 2026, https://closertohubertvaneyck.be/en/.

Fig. 5

to the 16th century, and that what conservator-restorers "mercilessly scraped away" was the work of Jan van Eyck, who had painted over the cruder work of Hubert.[8] Verougstraete speculated that because "since they erased a beautiful layer, only to lay bare a layer of an obvious lesser quality, one can assume they erased Jan and laid bare Hubert."[9] Of the lamb, she called it "perhaps the biggest error made by the restorers," and that the removal of Jan's naturalistic face had resulted in a hybrid lamb.[10] Coppens and Verougstraete perceive this change as the destruction of Jan's "superior" work. If this were true, it would be in complete conflict with the purpose of the restoration.

Verougstraete and Coppens's suspicions are not completely unfounded. It is known that Hubert died in 1426, and that Jan completed the altarpiece in 1432. A quatrain on the outside of the side panels reads: "Painter Hubert van Eyck, there is no greater artist, started this work and his brother Jan, who equaled him in art, completed the task at the request of Judocus Vijd. With a verse in memory of the sixth of May 1432, he requests that you preserve this work with care." (Fig. 5). By the nature of its creation, the painting is quite literally multilayered, making it difficult to identify which paint layers were executed by the van Eyck brothers and which represent later contributions. However, it is unknown which portions of the panels can be attributed to which brother. To call the Eyckian lamb's new face the work of Hubert based solely on its lessened naturalism is simply an assumption. The *Adoration of the Lamb* panel is the

8 Coppens, "Agnus Dei," 2024, 13, Closertohubertvaneyck.be.
9 Verougstraete, "The Catastrophic Restoration."
10 Ibid.

Fig. 6

Fig. 7

only known work of Hubert's that survives, so it seems presumptive to discriminate between the brothers' work on the basis of perceived skill.[11] As indicated in the original quatrain, Hubert's skills were regarded by their contemporaries as equal to Jan's. The preference for the passive and naturalistic lamb is retrospective. Jan van Eyck has had centuries to be canonized as a master of European oil painting. The restored lamb upsets this. Verougstraete and Coppens's fundamental qualm with the restoration of the *Adoration of the Lamb* is that the unnatural lamb simply does not make sense to them, based on what they know the abilities and intentions of Jan van Eyck to have been. How can we make sense of this? How is it possible that the alleged destruction of such an important painting was carried out?

The answer to many of Verougstraete and Coppens's concerns can be discerned from the published scientific data and from the restoration rationale. The availability of this documentation is exceptional, made public by the Flemish government's funding of the restoration. The effort was perhaps the most public and high-profile art restoration of recent history, with much of the treatment carried out behind glass at the Museum of Fine Arts in Ghent, and extensive photographic documentation available online.[12] The effort involved the foremost scholars in early Netherlandish and van Eyckian curation, art history, and conservation science.[13] The restoration was so endowed due to the profound significance of the *Ghent Altarpiece* to Flemish culture, and carried out with the understanding that changes to its appearance could be culturally shocking.

How was the overpainting officially determined to be unoriginal? According to Dubois's doctoral research, a Ghent chronicle from Sep-

11 Hannah McGivern, "Ghent Altarpiece: Latest Phase of Restoration Unmasks the Humanised Face of the Lamb of God," The Art Newspaper, December 18, 2019, https://www.theartnewspaper.com/2019/12/18/ghent-altarpiece-latest-phase-of-restoration-unmasks-the-humanised-face-of-the-lamb-of-god.

12 See https://closertovaneyck.kikirpa.be/ghentaltarpiece/#home/sub=open&vis&bt.

13 Hélène Dubois, "The Conservation History of the Ghent Altarpiece," The Burlington Magazine 160, no. 1386 (2018): 765, https://www.jstor.org/stable/44870712.

tember 1550 records that two prominent painters—Lancelot Blondeel and Jan van Scorel of Utrecht—"washed" and "kissed" the altarpiece, language which could indicate that the painting was retouched.[14] Still, it's visually difficult to tell that the overpainting is not original. It was executed with azurite, red lakes, and lead white, pigments which are consistent with the materials utilized in the era of the van Eycks.[15] And, like Coppens warned, there is not a reliable way to date paint pigments outside of identifying anachronistic material, which the *Adoration of the Lamb* does not contain.[16] Thus, the distinction between the original work of the van Eycks and later additions cannot be made chemically. Rather, it must be deduced from the art-historical record, and from the thick layer of yellow varnish which separated the differing expressions of the mystic lamb.

Perhaps more emboldening than evidence which could indicate the date of the overpaint, developments in conservation scientific analysis, as well as a protective varnish, meant that the underlying authentic lamb was both intact and accessible. Along with high-resolution color photography, X-radiography, infrared imaging, and paint sample analysis, macroscopic and microscopic X-ray fluorescence elemental mapping was used by 21st century conservators to identify discrepancies between the earlier and later applications of paint.[17] Mapping for mercury, which is associated with the red pigment vermillion, revealed the smaller and higher-set nostrils of the Eyckian lamb (Fig. 6); this composition is also visible in a false-color hyperspectral infrared reflectance image, which displays the dark preparatory underdrawing lines of prominent lips (Fig. 7).[18] Further indicating that the naturalistic lamb was a later addition, the overpainted ears were added on top of the gilded, radiating halo—typically the last step in the painting process.[19]

Ultimately, the material and art-historical evidence that the naturalistic lamb was unoriginal was considered ample enough by the authorities. This conclusion disrupted centuries of intense theological and art-historical devotion to the precise qualities of the previous lamb, and it encouraged an ambitious undertaking to reveal the authentic one at the risk of damaging pigment applied by one of history's most celebrated artists. Luckily, the presence of varnish between the visible overpaint and the detected underpaint vastly reduced the riskiness of removing six-century-old paint.[20] This protective varnish

14 Ibid., 765.
15 Ibid., 765.
16 Nicholas Eastaugh, "Scientific Dating of Paintings," Infocus Magazine, no. 1 (2006): 38, https://www.rms.org.uk/resource/infocus--1-march-2006-scientific-dating-of-paintings-pdf.html
17 Geert Van der Snickt et al., "Large-Area Elemental Imaging Reveals Van Eyck's Original Paint Layers on the Ghent Altarpiece (1432), Rescoping Its Conservation Treatment," Angewandte Chemie International Edition 56, no. 17 (2017): 4800, https://doi.org/10.1002/anie.201700707.
18 Van der Snickt, "Eyckian Lamb of God Reveals Secrets," KIK-IRPA, 2020, 2.
19 Ibid.
20 Anne Van Grevenstein, "The Ongoing Conservation of the Ghent Altarpiece," CeROArt (June 2015): 7, https://doi.

meant that the overpaint could be removed with "only around a five percent loss of [Eyckian] paint."[21]

And so the naturalistic lamb was removed—mercilessly, if one sympathizes with Coppens and Verougstraete's interpretation of the authorship of the paint layers, but justly if one considers the extensive scientific and historical evidence to be sufficient justification. The instrument of removal chosen by conservators—the gleaming scalpel—certainly seems aggressive, but statements put out by the KIK-IRPA paint an image of meticulous and skillful conservators tending to centimeters of the panel, liberating the underlying paint layer through the magnifying eye of a binocular microscope; the incidental losses of the Eyckian surface were compensated for with precise retouching, which attempted to replicate van Eyck's "precise modeling."[22] After varnishing the precious result of the overpaint removal, the conservator-restorers restored the gestalt of the original image. They filled in the gaps and recolored them with reversible watercolor and resin-based paints, which they intended future conservators to be able to remove without damaging the authentic painting.[23] The unified execution of its recovered surface proclaims the authority of the image; the new lamb is let out into an unblemished pasture.[24] This treatment of the painting, while controversial with the general public and downright treacherous to scholars with investment in the overpainted image of the lamb, was completed in accordance with conservation ethics.

The restoration of the *Adoration of the Lamb* exemplifies the intrinsic complexities of evaluating significant, historical art, and how that evaluation differs between conservators and the broader art-viewing public. The prioritization of the original work of the famous van Eycks over the skillful overpainting by anonymous artists represents a relatively recent evolution in how audiences value historic paintings. As evidenced by the overpainted lamb, 16th-century conservation-restoration was an artisan activity, executed on subjective aesthetic grounds.[25] Contemporary professional conservation is distinguished by its application of natural sciences and reverence for historical material in the evaluation and treatment of artwork.[26] Identifying the treatment needs of any artwork requires reconciling the objective impulse of scientific methodology with the inherent subjectivity of art's aesthetic, historical, and cultural values.[27] In the case of the *Adoration of the Lamb,* the technical imaging and paint sample analysis provided objective chemical evidence

org/10.4000/ceroart.4625.

21 "The Conservation Treatment of the Ghent Altarpiece," KIK-IRPA, 2020, 3.

22 Ibid.

23 James Beck, "Reversibility, Fact or Fiction?: The Dangers of Art Restoration," Source: Notes in the History of Art 18, no. 3 (1999): 3, https://www.jstor.org/stable/23205061.

24 Vivian van Saaze, Installation Art and the Museum: Presentation and Conservation of Changing Artworks (Routledge, 2013), 48, https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003698012.

25 Ibid., 38.

26 Ibid., 39–40.

27 Ibid., 42.

that could not identify the artist behind each layer but clearly signaled that the earlier layer was intact. The historical record, in conjunction with the layering of the paint, indicated that the van Eycks' work laid beneath the varnish. Van Eyck's historical value to Flemish culture overwhelmed any historic or aesthetic value of the 16th century overpaint, and so the overpaint was removed to reveal the probable Eyckian layer.[28] The lamb that conservators revealed calls on theologians and art historians to reconsider the implications of the work, and asks audiences to connect anew with the van Eycks' iconography. The narrative of the celebrated naturalistic painting abilities of the van Eycks has been rewritten. Just as in the 16th century, the naturalistic expression of the mystic lamb is preferable to many modern audiences, even if it is inauthentic.[29] The fundamental controversy in the *Adoration of the Lamb's* restoration is that this subjective aesthetic value is not always aligned with objective scientific and historical evidence.[30] Because the removal of the overpaint was irreversible, those who preferred it now grieve.

This is the dilemma of restoring authenticity in such an iconic and historic work of art. By intervening in the *Adoration of the Lamb*, even for the sake of reviving an image of the past, conservators unavoidably implicate its image in the art history of the present.[31] Only with modern technological advancements could the lamb beneath the overpaint be discovered—and only with modern sensibilities and notions of authenticity's essentiality was the removal of the overpaint desirable. The *Adoration of the Lamb* has been restored to its 15th-century appearance. Now, modern audiences can congregate in St. Bavo's and look upon the biblical scene as though the Eyckian oils were still drying. Jan van Eyck is now so fundamental to the art-historical, religious, and cultural canons that, when confronted with evidence of his hidden handiwork within the altarpiece, the finest of resources were summoned to uncover the quiet mystery beneath. Now exposed for good, the Eyckian lamb does not conform to the renowned naturalism of van Eyck, nor to the aesthetic inclinations of subsequent centuries. Yet its cultural importance is no less profound. The world is ablaze with new fascination with the altarpiece. The gentle, bleeding lamb of God, with its confrontational gaze, deserves to be reconsidered.

28 O'Riordan, "Saving Great Works of Art," 431.

29 "Lamb's 'alarmingly humanoid' face," BBC News.

30 Mark Sagoff, "On Restoring and Reproducing Art," The Journal of Philosophy 75, no. 9 (1978): 456, https://www.jstor.org/stable/2025386.

31 Cathleen Hoeniger, "The Restoration of the Early Italian "Primitives" During the 20th Century: Valuing Art and Its Consequences," Journal of the American Institute for Conservation 38, no. 2 (1999): 144, https://www.jstor.org/stable/3180043.

THE COSTS OF REVOLUTION:

Mariana Yampolsky's An Attack on a Train Directed by a Priest from the portfolio 'ESTAMPAS DE LA REVOLUCIÓN MEXICANA'

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In Mariana Yampolsky's "Asalto al tren de Guadalajara dirigido por el cura Angulo, 13 de abril de 1927" [An Attack on the Guadalajara Train Directed by the priest Angulo, April 13, 1927], a group of men, spurred on by a priest, rush toward a train with weapons and torches raised (fig. 1). The Taller de Gráfica Popular (The People's Graphic Workshop or TGP) published the print in 1947 in Mexico City as part of the *Estampas de la Revolución Mexicana* [Prints from the Mexican Revolution] portfolio. In this work, Yampolsky vividly renders the darker aspects of revolution—namely, the loss of civilian life in conflict. "Asalto al tren" illuminates the complexities of battle, highlighting the fervor of revolution and the toll it takes on ordinary people. In examining Yampolsky's career, her connection to the TGP, and the Mexican Revolution portfolio as a whole, this paper assesses how Yampolsky and the TGP represent historical narratives while highlighting the experience of the underclass in revolutionary Mexico.

Yampolsky's emphasis on civilian suffering in this work reflects her broader concern for the impact of violence on noncombatants. As the daughter of a mother who escaped Nazi Germany and a father who fled from antisemitic persecution in Russia, Yampolsky was shaped by the consequences of state violence and displacement. After TGP artists presented at the University of Chicago, where she was a student, Yampolsky moved to Mexico to join them.[1] Her consistent engagement with the organization led her to become a director and manager, where she helped organize major exhibitions for the group.[2] Yampolsky was committed to the political power of art. "I can't conceive of art without a social context," she said in 1982. "It's not just what you as an individual want to express; it must be understandable by others."[3] Yampolsky's belief in artists' social responsibility defined her broader career.

"Asalto al tren" differs from Yampolsky's oeuvre, which typically favors hopeful, domestic scenes of campesino (peasant or farmer) life—parents and children or husbands and wives.[4] The lithograph features a multilayered narrative that initially appears celebratory due to its use of the machete, a revolutionary symbol, and a unifying triangular compositional structure. However, with rel-

1 Helga Prignitz-Poda, "Mariana Yampolsky," in From Posada to Isotype, from Kollwitz to Catlett: Exchanges of Political Print Culture: Germany–Mexico, 1900–1968, exh. cat., ed. Benjamin H.D. Buchloh and Michelle N. Harewood (Museo Nacional Centro de Arte Reina Sofía, 2022), 356, https://issuu.com/museoreinasofia/docs/posada_isotype_eng/358.

2 Ibid., 357.

3 Shifra M. Goldman, "Six Women Artists of Mexico," Woman's Art Journal 3, no. 2 (1982): 5, https://www.jstor.org/stable/1358027.

4 Prignitz-Poda, "Mariana Yampolsky," 358.

Fig. 1 Mariana Yampolsky, "An Attack on a Train Directed by a Priest" 1947, linocut, Sheet: 10 5/8 × 15 3/4 in., Image: 8 11/16 × 11 13/16 in., from the portfolio *Estampas de La Revolución Mexicana*. Reproduced by The Metropolitan Museum of Art.

evant historical context, a darker tale of religious manipulation and exploitation emerges, revealing how the TGP simplifies history to construct a homogenized image of rural class identity.

"Asalto al tren" depicts a historical train attack that took place on April 13, 1927, in Guadalajara as part of the Cristero Rebellion.[5] The rebellion was a widespread uprising in the rural areas of central western Mexico. Although the conflict itself unfolded between 1926 and 1929, tensions began in 1917 following amendments to the Mexican Constitution that limited the power of the Catholic Church. After President Plutarco Elías Calles passed a law officially separating church and state in 1926, the war between the Cristero soldiers and the Federal government began.[6]

The war devastated rural communities in Mexico. Due to famine, epidemics, and violence caused by the rebellion, the populations of villages across central western Mexico dropped dramatically. These factors make it nearly impossible to place precise estimates on the number of civilian deaths.[7] The rebellion spurred mass

5 "Drive on Outlaw Bands Is Continued in Mexico: Many Term Train Attacks Catholic Rebellion and Offer Calles Aid," The Washington Post, April 27, 1927, https://www.proquest.com/newspapers/drive-on-outlaw-bands-is-continued-mexico/docview/149791394/se-2?accountid=189667.

6 Mariana Yampolsky, "An Attack on a Train Directed by a Priest (Cura Angulo)" (plate 63), from Estampas de La Revolución Mexicana [Prints from the Mexican Revolution], 1947, linocut, Metropolitan Museum of Art, https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/714896?pkgids=941; John A. Britton, "Cristero Rebellion," in Encyclopedia of Latin American History and Culture, 2nd ed., ed. Jay Kinsbruner and Erick D. Langer, (Charles Scribner's Sons, 2008), 2:657–658.

7 Jean A. Meyer, The Cristero Rebellion: The Mexican People between Church and State, 1926–1929 (Cambridge

emigration, with about 500,000 civilians moving to larger cities within Mexico and another 500,000 crossing the border into the United States.[8] With around one million people displaced, the war left a lasting impact on communities across the region.

As campesinos, Cristero soldiers started the war without weapons, uniforms, or military training. Over the course of the war, the Cristeros mobilized, utilizing guerrilla tactics and their home-field advantage against federal troops.[9] By 1927, the Cristeros had created an organized army consisting primarily of skilled cavalrymen.[10] The Cristero soldiers were fierce, loyal, and unified by a cause for which they were willing to die.

At first, the federal government did not take the threat posed by the Cristero army seriously. Once federal troops began engaging the Cristeros, they were blindsided by the rebels' organization and strength. By the end of the conflict in 1929, 100,000 combatants had died: 60,000 federal soldiers, and 40,000 Cristeros.[11] Despite the overwhelming power of the Cristero army, the rebellion ended in a truce between the Church and federal authorities. With their military success, victory had seemed within reach for the Cristeros, but it was undermined by unceremonious negotiations brokered by the Church.[12]

The conflict was complex and multifaceted, but the TGP's description of the Cristero Rebellion, which accompanied Yampolsky's print in the *Prints from the Mexican Revolution* portfolio, ignored and flattened its intricacies:

In 1927, Church dignitaries transformed themselves into disrupters of the peace. Every day, news would arrive stating that priests were carrying out illegal acts. What did they want? They wanted to go back to enjoying their unjust privileges. The Guadalajara train was attacked by the priest Angulo. Many innocent people were killed. The government was forced to take more robust measures to restore order, which was achieved with the support of the entire Mexican population.[13]

The story of the war is rewritten to construct a narrative of a wholly unified rural class, placing the blame solely on the Church. Here, the Cristeros, as rural workers and campesinos, did not attack the train; Father Angulo did. No longer did the conflict end in a truce between the Federal government and the Catholic Church; now, the government restored order with the support of the entire Mexican population. In reality, the Cristero Rebellion was a grassroots movement, led by a deeply religious community within the Mexican population. It is this complex historical narrative that Yampolsky and the TGP would eventually condense and reinterpret in the *Estampas de la Revolución Mexicana* collection.

University Press, 2008), 178.
8 Ibid., 179.
9 Ibid., 171–176.
10 Ibid., 118.
11 Ibid., 178.
12 Ibid., 201.

13 Alberto Morales Jimenez, trans. Aída Wester, text accompanying "Asalto al tren de Guadalajara dirigido por el cura Angulo, 13 de abril de 1927" (plate 63), New Mexico Museum of Art, https://sam.nmartmuseum.org/objects/20325/plate-63--asalo-al-tren-de-guadalajara-dirigido-por-el-cur?ctx=25ec84f6195ff8745574256b4a22b8bab14efc49&idxreinterpret=.

Visually, the dense composition of "Asalto al tren" makes the print difficult to parse. The linocut medium lends itself to this chaos, with figures and objects defined entirely by black and white shapes. The swirling lines and chaotic movement of the work suggest the disorder of revolutionary violence. Each figure is frozen mid-gesture. The ground itself appears to be in motion, churning and wave-like.

Yampolsky composed the scene using diagonal lines. The horizon is diagonal, making the work feel unbalanced, as if the men pouring into the train are causing the world itself to tip. Diagonal lines are formed by masses of figures, starting with a man charging into battle on his horse on the far left, followed by a section of uneven ground, then by a soldier pointing his rifle forward, and finally by the priest's robes and outstretched arm. The lines created by the man with the gun and the priest form a triangular composition. This central triangle of figures appears strong and balanced amidst the chaos of the scene, conveying organization and triumph. Set against the surrounding diagonals, this triangular structure introduces a moment of imposed order. Its visual solidity organizes the men into a coherent formation; the attack seems coordinated and purposeful despite the chaos that engulfs it.

Symbols of progress and revolution dominate the image. These reflect broader ideological elements of the Mexican Revolution and its aftermath, particularly the role modernization played in redistributing power to the lower classes. To the left of the central triangle, a soldier points his rifle at the train engine on the right. This gesture leads the eye from the soldier to the locomotive, a powerful symbol of industrial modernization and state authority in post-revolutionary Mexico. Railways played a central role in integrating rural regions into national systems of trade and governance, thereby consolidating state power. By targeting the engine, the source of the train's forward momentum, the soldiers interrupt the idea of progress through state-driven modernization.

The machete held by the soldier next to the priest functions as a different symbol. While the train engine symbolizes state-driven modernization, the machete evokes bottom-up social reform rooted in rural labor. The machete is a well-known symbol of social progress in Mexican art. As a traditional tool of manual labor, it carries connotations of class struggle and grassroots resistance.[14] Its presence, then, situates the soldiers within a visual language of popular revolt rather than an organized authority.

The men are identifiable as soldiers by their white uniforms, sombreros, and bandoliers. The central men are barefoot or wear sandals; they are poor, and not part of an official army. The markings used to distinguish figures from one another echo the texture of the train's material (see fig. 1). The two soldiers in the center of the composition are defined by large swatches of white with thinner, wispy black lines. These areas

14 The machete was used by revolutionary artists such as David Alfaro Siqueiros in Autorretrato (El Machete) and José Clemente Orozco in Pelea con Machetes (Machete Fight).

of white, enhanced with black, swirling details, echo the fire. The shading on the man between the two soldiers mimics the wood grain of the train cars in front of them. Together, echoing the textures of the burning train, these three men evoke the image of wood consumed by fire. This visual conflation suggests that these men are not autonomous agents, but fuel for a revolutionary blaze. They are absorbed into and consumed by the violence they enact.

The priest, identified by his robes and Roman collar, is the only figure clearly shown wearing shoes, setting him apart from the surrounding soldiers via his higher social standing. He is also the only figure in the work whose face is clearly rendered. Countless men stream past him, all without an identity, but the priest is given both a name and a likeness. By naming Father Angulo in the title, the print elevates him from a mere participant to a symbol of the Church's authority. His visual and narrative prominence concentrates responsibility for the violence onto a single clerical figure, reinforcing the TGP's critique of institutional religious power rather than the actions of the campesinos themselves. This separation is reinforced formally through texture and tone. Only the far right side of the composition, where the priest stands, contains solid shapes with minimal line definition. His robes and the locomotive are the only objects that are primarily black. Given that the soldiers' garb matches that of the train cars, the priest can be understood as a conductor, pulling these men along as the leader of this attack.

The priest directs the men toward the train, but his hand points directly into the flames. A clergyman pointing into a raging fire conjures the mental image of hellfire. Rather than revolutionaries fighting for justice, these men become instruments of religious manipulation, led by a priest using his authority to drive them towards damnation. The priest does not simply urge these men into battle; he directs them towards Hell.

This interpretation of the scene is cemented by the depictions of violence in the composition's back left corner. Here, civilians pour out of the burning train, covering their mouths to filter out the smoke. Among them, the only woman present in the scene tumbles headfirst out of the train while a man stands over her, prepared to strike her with his machete. Her vulnerability, emphasized by her isolation as the piece's only female figure, marks her as a stand-in for all rendered defenseless in this conflict: women, children, and other civilians who bear the cost of revolutionary violence. Her presence in the print draws attention away from heroic readings of the attack, shifting focus instead to the toll the uprising takes on the innocent. This emphasis on civilian suffering reflects not only Yampolsky's personal commitments but the broader ideological framework of the TGP, the workshop in which the work was disseminated.

The TGP advocated for its political goals through print media, including flyers, posters, and other street ephemera, an especially effective medium because

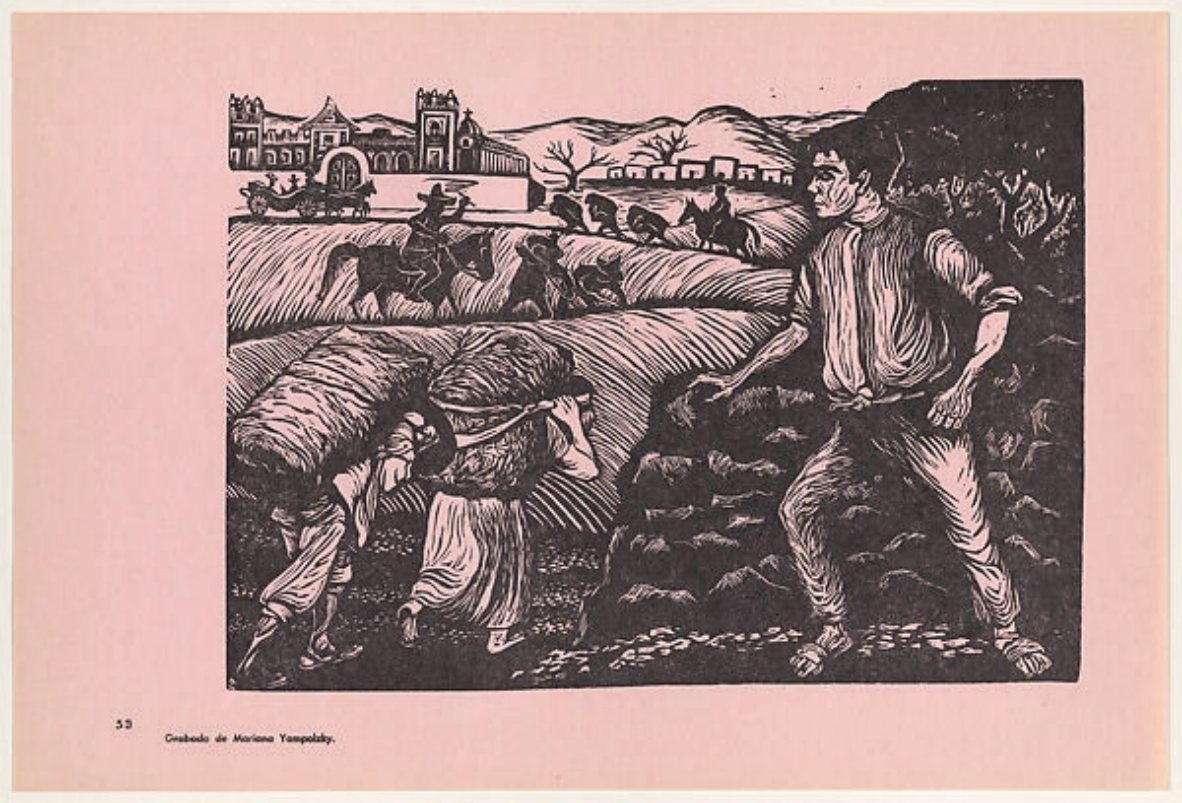

Fig. 2 Mariana Yampolsky, "La juventud de Emiliano Zapata: lección objetiva," 1947, linocut, Sheet: 10 5/8 × 15 3/4 in., Image: 8 11/16 × 11 13/16 in., from the portfolio Estampas de la Revolución Mexicana. Reproduced by The Metropolitan Museum of Art.

the works were inexpensive to produce and easy to distribute. Founded in 1937 in Mexico City and operating until 2010, the TGP was the world's longest-lasting artist collective.[15] From its earliest days, members of the TGP dedicated themselves to social progress across Mexico, lobbying and protesting for improved labor laws, increased access to education, and expanded human rights, while also circulating anti-fascist prints for international struggles against authoritarianism.[16]

To generate revenue, the TGP released limited collections, prints, and portfolios.[17] Perhaps the most influential of these portfolios was *Estampas de la Revolución Mexicana*, a portfolio produced in five hundred editions for the TGP's tenth anniversary in 1947.[18] The collection comprises eighty-five prints by

15 Mark P. McDonald, Mexican Prints at the Vanguard, exh. cat. (Metropolitan Museum of Art, 2024), 28; "Taller de Gráfica Popular (Mexico City, Mexico)," Art Institute of Chicago, accessed December 17, 2024, https://www.artic.edu/artists/72887/taller-de-grafica-popular-mexico-city-mexico.

16 Theresa Avila, "El Taller de Gráfica Popular and the Chronicles of Mexican History and Nationalism," Third Text 28, no. 3 (2014): 311, https://doi.org/10.1080/09528822.2014.930578.

17 Diane Miliotes, What May Come: The Taller de Gráfica Popular and the Mexican Political Print (Yale University Press, 2014), 7.

18 Judith Keller, Block Prints and Lithographs by Artists of the TGP, exh. cat., (Archer M. Huntington Art Gallery, College of Fine Arts, 1985), 20; "Taller de Gráfica Popular, Estampas de La Revolución Mexicana, Metropolitan Museum of Art, https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/714128. There is an inconsistency in the number of editions produced. On the Met's website and in Theresa Avila's "Chronicles of Revolution and Nation: El Taller de Gráfica Popular's 'Estampas de La Revolución Mexicana' (1947)," the number is placed at 500 editions, while Judith Keller reports 550 editions in her Block Prints and Lithographs by Artists of the TGP.

Fig. 3 Mariana Yampolsky, "Vivac de Revolucionarios," 1947, linocut, Sheet: 10 5/8 × 15 3/4 in., Image: 9 1/16 × 11 13/16 in., from the portfolio Estampas de La Revolución Mexicana. Reproduced by The Metropolitan Museum of Art.

sixteen artists, with an index containing a description of each print as well as the TGP's "Declaration of the Principles."[19] *Estampas de la Revolución Mexicana* is representative of the TGP's views and cements the workshop's stylistic practices.[20] The collection depicts Mexican history, with prints one through nineteen addressing oppression under the dictatorship of Porfirio Díaz from 1876 to 1911, prints twenty through fifty-seven depicting the Mexican Revolution from 1910 to 1920, and prints fifty-eight through eighty-five focusing on post-war reconstruction of the 1920s, 30s, and 40s.[21] Yampolsky created prints for each of these sections.

Yampolsky produced three linocuts for the portfolio. Plate eight, "La Juventud de Emiliano Zapata: lección objetiva" [The Young Emiliano Zapata: An Objective Lesson], corresponds to the pre-revolutionary period in the collection and shows a fictionalized scene of a young revolutionary leader witnessing injustice (fig. 2).[22] It mythologizes Zapata's

19 Taller de Gráfica Popular, Estampas de la Revolución Mexicana [Prints of the Mexican Revolution] (Taller de Gráfica Popular, 1947), Metropolitan Museum of Art.

20 For an in depth analysis of the Estampas de La Revolución Mexicana's role in cementing the TGP's style, see Judith Keller's Block Prints and Lithographs by Artists of the TGP.

21 Avila, "Chronicles of Revolution and Nation," 1, 315.

22 The Met's website refers to this print as "The young Emiliano Zapata watching a scene in which workers in a field

life, illustrating the revolutionary feeling disgusted by abuses he witnesses against workers in a field. Despite the dark contents of the scene, the work remains hopeful and serene. Light is cast upon Zapata's face as he, per the text accompanying the print, swears that he will take this land back for the working class. The print deifies him; it claims ahistorically that Zapata was dedicated to the revolution his entire life and does not acknowledge that his formal political involvement began when he was elected president of his village council at thirty years old.[23]

Plate forty-nine, "Vivac de Revolucionarios" [Revolutionaries' Camp] depicts an idealized revolutionary camp in which men and women, given a moment of rest, lay down their arms and sing together (fig. 3).[24] The print depicts women as an integral part of revolutionary armies as combatants, a narrative not otherwise depicted in *Prints from the Mexican Revolution*. The harsh conditions of a military camp are not evident here. All figures are healthy and well-groomed. The women, too, serve a glamorized role. Typically, women who attached themselves to revolutionary camps faced social stigma. They were associated with prostitutes and seen as unclean and hyper-sexual.[25] Yampolsky flattens this narrative, depicting a much more optimistic view of the interactions between men and women in these camps.

In Plates Eight and Forty-Nine, Yampolsky used ahistorical narratives to present positive views of the pre-revolution period and the Mexican Revolution. These prints present a mythologized version of history, subtly distorting narratives to be more optimistic. These prints selectively altered historical events to construct a cohesive, idealized vision of rural and revolutionary life, effectively mythologizing entire aspects of Mexican history. Reworking Mexican history to better fit the TGP's vision of a unified rural Mexico was a common practice in the workshop. Artists often depicted campesinos not as a diverse, complex population but as a one-dimensional unified mass, simplifying rural communities into symbols of revolutionary solidarity.[26] This approach reinforced the TGP's broader political goals, presenting a cohesive image of popular revolt that emphasized collective identity over individual experience. "Asalto al tren" is not represented positively. Instead, it portrays a far darker, more critical depiction of events, refusing to shy away from the harsh realities of revolutionary movements.

Within the context of "Asalto al tren," the ahistorical narrative put forward by the TGP absolves the Cristero soldiers of their crimes. The violence they are enacting is portrayed as a force of nature, an overwhelming power causing them to crash into the train car as a mindless mass. Instead of being understood as a group of soldiers unified by a common cause, these men are treated as though they have simply been swept

carry heavy loads, while others are being whipped."

23 Avila, "Chronicles of Revolution and Nation," 182.

24 The Met's Website refers to this print as "Revolutionaries gathered and singing songs pertinent to their cause."

25 Avila, "Chronicles of Revolution and Nation," 277–280

26 Avila, "Chronicles of Revolution and Nation: El Taller de Gráfica Popular's 'Estampas de La Revolución Mexicana' (1947)," 320.

into a wave of revolutionary and religious zeal. They remain without identity, while Father Angulo is immortalized as a villain for causing the attack and manipulating the campesinos into supporting the rebellion.

Mariana Yampolsky's "Asalto al tren" illustrates the complexities inherent in revolution, making clear the fervor of revolution and its toll on civilians. Unlike her broader portfolio, which typically celebrates domestic and communal life, this print centers the experiences of campesinos caught in conflict. By depicting the priest as a central figure orchestrating violence, Yampolsky critiques the manipulation of rural communities by figures of authority into committing violent acts. The inclusion of the sole woman in the composition underscores the vulnerability of civilians, stressing the tangible consequences of hierarchical and religious control. In this print, she embraces violent imagery, not shying away from the realities of conflict but still inaccurately presenting the campesino population as wholly unified against the Cristero Rebellion. With the TGP, Mariana Yampolsky sought to depict this event, and by extension, the Cristero Rebellion, as a movement that negatively affected rural civilians. However, as demonstrated by the TGP's reductive description of the Cristero Rebellion and the group's broader tendency to reimagine history to fit a cohesive narrative of rural unity and progress, this approach oversimplified the complex historical realities of the war. "Asalto al tren" demonstrates Yampolsky's ability to confront the darker realities of revolution while maintaining focus on those most affected. The print challenges simplified narratives of revolutionary heroism and exposes the human cost of social upheaval. Beyond its historical context, the work raises questions about the responsibility of artists and institutions in shaping public understanding of history. The broader truth behind the Cristero Rebellion and the TGP's ahistorical narratives about Mexican history encourage us to consider the subtler mechanisms of authority exercised by those who construct and disseminate historical memory.

Love Language

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Mixed Media 2024

Love Language depicts an abstracted form of language that I value as a way to communicate with my grandparents. Even though I can not speak Vietnamese with them, they always send boxes of the fruit that I love, which I view as their way of showing affection in lieu of verbal communication. Utilizing cardboard as a canvas, the work includes drawings of wax apples, persimmon, and dragonfruit in varying styles. I included realistic colored pencil drawings, cut-out collage shapes, and flat acrylic paintings as the collection of fruit. I explored the idea of 3D objects on a 2D drawing by using foam mesh and additive layers. The notebook paper on the border of the drawing further references language in a more literal sense.